bargain collectively; I'd served six terms as president of my own union and had led the Screen Actors Guild in its first strike. I was the first president of the United States who was a lifetime member of an AFL-CIO union. But no president could tolerate an illegal strike by Federal employees. Unions can strike a business and shut it down, but you cannot allow a strike to shut down a vital government service.

Governments are different from private industry. I agreed with Calvin Coolidge, who said, "There is no right to strike against the public safety by anybody, anywhere, at any time."

Congress had passed a law forbidding strikes by government employees, and every member of the controllers' union had signed a sworn affidavit agreeing not to strike. I told Lewis to tell leaders of the union that I expected them to abide by it. After our meeting, there was a brief resumption of negotiations. But on the morning of August 3, after the union's executive board rejected a tentative agreement, more than seventy percent of the FAA's force of nearly seventeen thousand controllers went on strike.

I suppose this was the first real national emergency I faced as president. The strike endangered the safety of thousands of passengers on hundreds of airline flights daily, and threatened more harm to our already troubled economy. But I never had any doubt how to respond to it. That morning, I sent a directive to FAA supervisors and to those controllers who had crossed the picket lines and were at work in the control towers and radar rooms; I instructed them, above all, to maintain the safety of the airways. Flight operations were to be reduced to the level the system could accommodate *safely*. Then I called reporters to the Rose Garden and read a handwritten statement I'd drafted in my study the night before.